Introduction

IN 2015, A Delhi-based motor accidents tribunal adjudicated that animal-driven, slow-moving vehicles (or bullock carts) often caused serious accidents. Instead of banning these vehicles from the road, the court simply asked for them to be regulated.[1] The story serves as a metaphor for India's tendency to add the new to the old, instead of replacing it. A century after the first motor car appeared on the streets of India, bullock carts, animals (cows, buffaloes and dogs) and humans still share the same streets with motor vehicles. In most countries, horse-driven carriages disappeared within a few years of the arrival of motor cars. As recently as the 1980s, one of India's leading technical schools, the Indian Institute of Management, even had a project to build a better bullock cart that would carry heavier loads but with less wear and tear for the bullocks.[2]

India's desire to combine the traditional with the modern permeates also the realm of its relations with the rest of the world. Addressing the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) for the first time as prime minister in September 2014, Narendra Damodardas Modi, championed the adoption of an International Yoga Day,[3] a proposal that was adopted by the UNGA on 11 December 2014.[4] During Modi's maiden address before the United States Congress on 8 June 2016, he chose to mention yoga as one of the cultural connections that bind the United States and India. 'Our people to people links are strong and there is close cultural connect between our societies,' he said, adding, 'SIRI [the intelligent personal assistant on iPhones] tells us that India's ancient heritage of Yoga has over 30 million practitioners in the US.'[5]